

The Ant and the Grasshopper

During the bright days of summer, an ant worked from morning until evening. She carried seeds, crumbs, and dry grains through a narrow path to her underground storehouse. The work was steady rather than dramatic, but every trip added a little more to the pile. Her neighbors often saw her pass and asked why she never rested in the sun.

A grasshopper nearby spent his days singing from a tall blade of grass. He loved the heat, the music of insects, and the easy meals he found in the meadow. When he saw the ant carrying another seed, he laughed kindly. "Summer is made for dancing," he said. "Why worry about cold days when the sky is so blue?" The ant paused long enough to answer, "Because the blue sky will not last forever." Then she returned to her work.

The grasshopper invited her to join his songs. Sometimes the ant wished she could. Yet she remembered last winter, when frost had covered the field and food had been difficult to find. She did not work because she disliked happiness. She worked so that future hardship would not take away every choice. By the end of summer, her storeroom was full, and she allowed herself a quiet evening of rest.

Autumn arrived with cooler winds. The grasshopper kept singing, but the grass became dry and the insects disappeared. Soon snow covered the meadow. Hungry and shivering, he went to the ant's door. He expected anger, because he had mocked her effort. Instead, she gave him a warm meal. After he had eaten, she asked him what he would do differently when spring returned.

The grasshopper lowered his head. "I will still sing," he said, "but I will also prepare." The ant nodded. She showed him how to gather and store food, and he helped her repair a passage damaged by rain. When summer came again, the meadow heard the grasshopper's music as before. But between songs, he worked beside the ants. He had learned that enjoyment and responsibility are not enemies; planning for tomorrow makes today's joy easier to keep.